

The Battle of Granicus, 334BC

Alexander invaded Asia with approximately 43 000 infantry and 5000 cavalry. He was met at the River Granicus by 20 000 Persian cavalry and nearly as many Greek mercenary infantry. The Persian army was led by several important Persian nobles, including Spithridates, the satrap of Lydia and Ionia, and Arsites, the governor of northern Phrygia. It was early summer and the river was fairly narrow with steep banks in places. Beyond the river, on the Persian side, the ground was at first flat, then it gradually rose into low hills.

The Persian cavalry deployed along one side of the river bank. The Persians were strongest on the left wing opposite Alexander himself. The Greek mercenaries were well to the rear. Alexander had cavalry on both wings, supported on the right by some archers and the Agrianians. The pezetairoi and hypaspists were in the centre. His Greek and Thracian infantry were not used.

The battle

Alexander's tactics called for a massed cavalry attack by the right-hand side of his army against the Persian left wing. He sent a force of light cavalry, the Prodromoi and Paeonians, and some Companion cavalry across the river first. While they diverted the Persians' attention, Alexander and the remaining Companions outflanked the Persian

cavalry and charged into them. This gave the Macedonians the advantage. Arrian (1.15) describes the fighting as violent and desperate. During this attack Alexander killed two key Persian commanders—Mithridates and Rhoesaces. He was nearly killed himself but Cleitus the Black saved his life by killing his attacker, Spithridates.

The loss of so many of their leaders and the ability of Alexander's cavalry to get across the river changed the situation for the Persians. The Macedonian phalanx and hypaspists took advantage of the chaos among the Persian cavalry who were fighting Alexander and crossed the river to engage them in the centre. The Persians in the centre promptly turned and ran. The Greek mercenaries fighting on the Persian side stopped on a hill and asked for terms. Alexander refused, attacked and killed all but 2000 who were sent to Macedon as slaves.

Result of the victory

According to Arrian (1.16) the Persian cavalry lost 1000 to 2500 men. The Macedonian losses were said to be as low as 85 cavalry and 30 infantry. Arrian gives several reasons for the victory: Things soon turned in favour of Alexander's men; their experience and the weight of the attack began to tell, added to the advantage of the long cornel-wood spear [used by the Macedonian cavalry] over the light

lances [javelins] of the Persians.

ARRIAN, *THE CAMPAIGNS OF ALEXANDER*, 1.15

According to Plutarch (*Life of Alexander*, 16) and Diodorus Siculus (17.21.4) the battle was won primarily because of the actions and bravery of Alexander himself. Modern historians such as JFC Fuller pay credit to Alexander and his skilful deployment of the cavalry on his right wing.

The victory at Granicus gave Alexander control of Asia Minor. Most of the Persian leaders for the area were dead or disgraced. Many key Persian cities surrendered immediately, including Sardis, the Persian treasury for the area. This gave Alexander a great amount of money with which to finance the next part of his campaign. The victory also gave his men the confidence to continue with the campaign.

Analyse the battle

- Copy the diagram of the battle into your book. Divide it into two stages. Write a paragraph describing each stage.
- List the reasons why Alexander won this battle.
- Read Arrian's *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 1.14–16 and write a description of the battle (a) as one of the Companion cavalry under Alexander's command; (b) as one of the Persian nobles.

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